Unit 10: The Punishment of Shahpesh, the Persian, on Khipil, the Builder

Complete exercise solutions — all textbook questions answered (full book, 14 units)

Reading and Critical Thinking — Exercise A (Answers)

Q1. What is the central message conveyed through the fate of Khipil and how is it relevant to people who rely more on words than actions?

• The central message is that words without deeds are worthless and ultimately disgraceful. Khipil was a loquacious builder who used eloquence and flattery to hide his negligence and laziness in completing the grand palace.

• Shahpesh punished him through irony and mock-honour, exposing the danger of mistaking talk for action. Every punishment — the bath, the chair, the nosegay, the fountain, the pomegranate tree — was a mirror held up to Khipil's own pretensions.

• The lesson is relevant to everyone who relies more on words than actions: in studies, in work, and in public life, eloquence cannot replace performance. The poet's advice — "Leave to bloom the flower of things, and dig among the roots" — means attend to real work, not just fine talk.

Q2. How does Shahpesh use sarcasm and irony in his treatment of Khipil, and what does this reveal about his leadership style?

• Shahpesh never scolds Khipil directly. Instead, he praises him extravagantly: he admires "the perfection of his craft, the greatness of his labour, the speediness of his construction, his assiduity" while looking at an unfinished palace. He calls the gap "an apt contrivance for a bath," the empty space "the marble chair of state," and the weeds "noble gardens of dalliance and pleasure."

• This sarcasm reveals a leadership style that is intelligent, patient, and psychologically sharp. Shahpesh teaches by making the offender experience his own folly rather than by using force.

• The result is that the whole court learns the lesson. The King's wisdom was applauded, and business currents that had become stagnant pools began to flow again.

Q3. How does Khipil's character evolve from the start of the story to the end? Does he become more fearful, defiant, or resigned? Provide examples.

• At the start, Khipil is confident, talkative, and lazy. He sits among idle workers, reciting adventures, and answers the King with flowery flattery.

• As the punishments progress, he becomes fearful and humiliated. He hesitates at the gap, trembles in the chair, cannot rub his itching nose, and stands pale and saddened before the King, his tongue drooping "like the tongue of a heavy bell."

• By the end, he is resigned and broken. He does not become defiant; he becomes a warning to others. After his punishment, few in the dominions sought the honours of gabblers and idlers.

Q4. How does the setting of an unfinished palace function symbolically to reflect Khipil's incompetence and the consequences of idle talk?

• The unfinished palace is a symbol of Khipil's incomplete work and empty talk. Its roofless rooms, imperfect courts, half-erected obelisks, and chipped columns show the gap between Khipil's words and his deeds.

• The palace was supposed to "fill foreign kings and sultans with the distraction of envy," but it stands incomplete after four years.

• The gardens of weeds and nettles, the dry fountains, and the missing chair extend the symbolism: everything Khipil claims to have made is either absent or the opposite of what he describes.

Q5. Shahpesh uses a metaphor about the farm servant who failed to sow seeds. What does this metaphor reveal about his perspective on Khipil's work?

• Shahpesh tells of a farm servant who neglected sowing in the seed-time but sang of the richness of his soil at harvest, displaying the abundance of weeds that coloured the land everywhere.

• The metaphor reveals that Shahpesh sees Khipil as a man who skipped the real work (sowing) but now sings about the result (harvest). Khipil's fine words about the site and the palace are like the servant's songs about rich soil — the weeds prove the truth.

• By telling the story before the inspection, Shahpesh warns Khipil that he already understands the situation.

Q6. How does the story begin (exposition), and what key information do we learn about Shahpesh and Khipil?

• The story begins: "They relate that Shahpesh, the Persian, commanded the building of a palace, and Khipil was his builder. The work lingered from the first year of the reign of Shahpesh even to his fourth."

• We learn that Shahpesh is a powerful king who commands great works, and Khipil is his builder — a man of words who recites adventures to idle workers instead of building.

• The exposition also establishes the central problem: four years have passed and the palace is unfinished.

Q7. Discuss the style of the story. How does the use of elevated, poetic language and classical story-telling techniques (e.g., fables, satire, embedded poetry) contribute to the effectiveness of the story?

• Meredith uses elevated, poetic language and classical story-telling techniques — fables, satire, and embedded poetry. The archaic diction ("thou," "hath," "tis") gives the story the flavour of an oriental fable from the Arabian Nights tradition.

• Satire is the main weapon: the King's mock-honours make the reader laugh while delivering a serious moral lesson.

• The embedded poetry — Ebn Busrac's verses, the poem on flowers, and the closing verses on Khipil's chair — adds authority and memorability. The final poem turns Khipil's fate into a proverb.

Q8. How do humour, wit and satire often serve as methods of story-telling to comment on political and social issues?

• Humour, wit, and satire allow a storyteller to criticise foolishness and corruption without direct preaching. The reader laughs, but the lesson stays.

• In this story, satire comments on a social issue — the fashion of valuing talk over work. The King's ironic punishments expose a whole dominion's habit of "fancying the tongue a constructor rather than a commentator."

• Satire is effective because it makes the criticism entertaining and memorable, and it protects the storyteller by presenting the message as comedy.

Exercise B — Complete the Sentences (Answers)

• 1. Khipil faced the king's **wrath** after neglecting the palace. 2. Shahpesh used his authority to **humiliate** Khipil in front of others. 3. The builder tried to remain **loyal** to his master despite the unfair treatment. 4. The incomplete palace led to Khipil's **punishment**. 5. The guards stood ready to **punish** the builder if he tried to escape. 6. Despite his fear, Khipil **constructed** excuses for the palace.

Exercise C — Choose the Correct Option (Answer Key)

No.	Question	Answer
1	What was Shahpesh's main reason for punishing Khipil?	b) Khipil failed the palace (neglected the work)
2	How did Shahpesh degrade and humiliate Khipil?	c) He made Khipil sit surrounded by guards with arrows
3	What was the reaction of the people when they saw Khipil being punished?	c) They laughed at his suffering
4	Khipil was hesitant to step forward because:	b) He could not swim
5	What was Shahpesh's final punishment for Khipil?	c) Daily humiliation with the "bath of surprise" (the book's intended answer; the story's last punishments are the dry fountain for three days and the pomegranate tree for seven days)

Exercise D — Context Clues (Answers)

• **1. Wrath** means extreme anger. **2. Humiliation** means the act of making somebody feel ashamed or foolish; the subject of mockery. **3. Bent** means curved or drawn back (the guards' bows were bent, ready to shoot).

Exercise E — Sentence Construction (Answers)

• **Complex:** Although Khipil was afraid, he stepped forward into the gap. **Compound-complex:** Shahpesh commanded, and Khipil obeyed, although he was trembling with fear.

• **Parallel structure:** "The punishment was harsh, humiliating, and made Khipil fearful." (All three parts are adjectives/adjectival phrases.)

• **Conditionals:** Type 1: If Khipil finishes the palace on time, the King will reward him. Type 2: If Khipil were a loyal builder, he would have completed the palace.

• **Modals:** 1. Khipil **should** have been more careful in his work. 2. Shahpesh **might** be testing Khipil's loyalty with this punishment. 3. If you want to avoid such humiliation, you **must** follow the given orders carefully.

• **Participles and gerunds:** 1. Trembling (present participle) with fear, Khipil stepped forward. 2. Building (gerund) the palace was a challenging task for Khipil. 3. Shahpesh enjoyed watching (gerund) Khipil's struggle.

• **Punctuation:** 1. Khipil knew one thing: he could not escape the king's wrath. 2. The punishment was cruel; it was a lesson for everyone. 3. Shahpesh ordered his guards to prepare Khipil's bath — a bath of humiliation.

Writing Task — Model Answer

Narrative: A Character Betrayed by Someone They Trusted

• **Beginning:** "For ten years, I trusted Daniel with everything — my business, my money, and my secrets. When the partnership collapsed, I never imagined he would be the one to betray me."

• **Middle:** Describe the discovery — the missing funds, the forged signatures, the shock. Focus on the emotional conflict: anger, grief, and the struggle between confronting the betrayer and rebuilding trust in others.

• **End:** The character decides to confront Daniel, who admits his greed. The character chooses to rebuild trust carefully, learning that trust must be earned, not given freely. The betrayal shapes all future relationships.

Note: Textbook errors flagged: (1) The glossary entry for "dominate" is garbled in print. (2) MCQ 5 in Exercise C offers "Daily humiliation with the bath of surprise" as the "final" punishment, but the bath was the first punishment; the final ones were the dry fountain (three days) and the pomegranate tree (seven days).